

Has the "White Left" Tide of Thought Already Invaded China?

Zhihu

The "white left" (bai zuo) current is the ideology of the age of transnational capitalist production. Chinese capital has already begun its process of globalisation, vertically integrating the factors of production across the whole world and carrying out transnational production. According to the principle that the economic base determines the superstructure, a "white left" current is bound to develop slowly in China as well.

Interestingly, the Chinese scholar Zhai Dongsheng has written a special article discussing exactly this question. He even raised the point: if Asians do not believe in the "white left," might they not develop a "yellow left" current of thought to serve a similar function?

Some time ago I was invited to lecture to the China-based executives of a Global 500 company, and chatted with seven of their executives for three hours. Although the topic was global political and economic trends, from their subtle interactions and heated discussion I suddenly became aware of this question: the living soil of the white-left tide is very likely this very class of senior international wage-labourers within the global multinational corporations. After presenting this theoretical conjecture to the students of the International Political Economy programme at Renmin University in class, I left them a homework assignment: against the background of Asian-capital multinationals — Chinese, Japanese, Korean, Singaporean — seizing an ever larger share of the Global 500, if my conjecture above holds, what kind of alternative ideology should we shape to provide lubrication and theoretical self-confidence for the global activities of Asian capital and its executive class? Can it be named the "yellow left" current?

The core values of the white left, as summarised by a Chinese teacher, run roughly as follows:

"White left" usually refers to the cultural left of Europe and America. Their propositions concentrate on social issues, including but not limited to: 1. Equal-rights movements: supporting racial equality, gender equality, LGBT rights, body positivity, etc., and stressing "political correctness." 2.

Environmentalism: concerned with climate change and animal protection, opposed to industry's destruction of nature. 3. Humanitarianism: opposing the death penalty, supporting the rights of immigrants and refugees, and championing multiculturalism. 4. Free choice: advocating abortion rights, euthanasia, drug decriminalisation, and other personal freedoms. Source:

<https://mp.weixin.qq.com/s/oxm9NL3MFsPxvJBaUZk6SQ>

Among these, the parts that do not overlap with the liberalism of the national-capitalist stage are mainly: support for racial equality, concern over climate change, championing of multiculturalism, and protection of refugees and immigrants. The other items — drug criminalisation, abortion, euthanasia, opposition to the death penalty — had already arisen before transnational capitalism developed. Although these parts follow much the same trend, each nation has its own characteristics: East Asia, for instance, sentences drug trafficking quite harshly and does not support euthanasia.

To organise transnational production, one must support racial equality and champion multiculturalism; otherwise the enterprise will easily be consumed from within by racial contradictions. And under transnational capitalism cross-border movement of people is frequent, making immigration an everyday phenomenon — hence the greater importance attached to protecting immigrants' rights.

As Chinese people go further abroad with the export of capital, and as the ageing and shrinking domestic population in turn draws large-scale immigration of foreigners, the "white left" or "yellow left" current in Chinese society is bound to rise. In fact, in the fields of racial equality and climate change the Chinese official stance is already very positive — China already carries a certain "yellow left" character. This is closely connected with China's long-standing position as a centre of global capital accumulation and its deep enmeshment in global industrial chains. A country that does business with every nation, invites the bourgeoisies of all countries to invest, and wants its own capital to go out into the world — the ideology that dominates such a country is bound to take on a "white left" or "yellow left" hue.

As for "drug legalisation," "euthanasia," and the like, a "yellow left" would very likely propose a set of positions different from the "white left." In fact, in most countries of the world, including Europe and America, many people in society still call for severe punishment of drug crime; it is not so monolithic.

On the whole, as Zhai Dongsheng says, the "white left" and "yellow left" supply transnational capitalism with a set of ideologies. Seen from a nationalist standpoint, this ideology looks highly threatening; but from the standpoint of the great trend of transnational capitalist development, it is progressive. How the nation-state is to find its own ideology in a world of transnational capitalism — preserving its national character without going so far as xenophobia that obstructs capital accumulation — is a great problem. In this regard, Singapore has carried out a certain exploration and experiment. Recently, China — which learned a great deal from Singapore at the start of its reform era — launched its "unilateral opening" policy to attract global factors of production to gather in China, very likely also with reference to Singapore's experience. From Singapore we may glimpse the ideology of the future "yellow left" empire seated at the centre of the capitalist world-system.

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